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Train to Pakistan: against Mainstream Representations of the Partition of India?

The trouble is precisely that no wicked heart,
a relatively rare phenomenon,
is necessary to cause great evil.
-- Arendt 423

In 1947, the independence of India was accompanied by its separation into the newly-formed States of Modern India and Pakistan. Alongside celebrations that marked the end of the British Raj, it is estimated that mass migrations and violent conflicts caused the death of one million people, while ten million others were made refugees and 75,000 women were abducted and raped (Butalia 3).

Since then, on the various sides of borders, the representations of this era have been paradoxical. On the one hand, in public monuments¹, school textbooks² and perhaps the work of some historians³, there has been a tendency to focus on the grand narrative of national liberation and to turn a blind eye on the Partition and its violence. On the other hand, survivors – whether they be victims, culprits or witnesses – have often kept an indelible memory of the horror of these events⁴. One could therefore oppose a mainstream a counter-representation of the Partition in terms of forgetting and remembering.

In this context, works of fiction have been seen as sites of memory and contestation. To quote two historians: “partition fiction (and some non-fiction) is almost the only social history we have of this time. . . . The point does need to be made that it is in fiction, rather than any other genre, that we find an attempt to assimilate the full import of what Partition meant” (Menon and Bhasin 22).

It is in this respect that *Train to Pakistan*, written by Khushwant Singh and published in 1956, is often considered a foundational novel (Mehrotra 220; Coussy 42; Roy 33-4⁵), one that reveals the horror of a forgotten past with both realism and bitterness (Raizada 127; Pabby 42-3; Wolpert ix⁶). However, if one distinguishes between two types of forgetting –

silence and self-exoneration – it becomes possible to suggest a re-reading of the text. *Train to Pakistan*, in this perspective, both undermines and upholds mainstream representations of the Partition.

In many ways, Singh's subversive novel discloses the horrors of Partition rather than concealing them. In one significant passage, the narrator reports the thoughts of Hukum Chand, the Magistrate of the small village of Mano Majra where the novel is set. Powerless in the face of mounting tensions, he exclaims:

Where was the power? What were the people in Delhi doing? Making fine speeches in the assembly! Loudspeakers magnifying their egos; lovely-looking foreign women in the visitor's galleries in breathless admiration. 'He is a great man, this Mr Nehru of yours. I do think he is the greatest man in the world today. Wasn't that a wonderful thing to say? 'Long years ago we made a tryst with destiny and now the time comes when we shall redeem our pledge, not wholly or in full measure but very substantially.' Yes, Mr Prime Minister, *you made your tryst*, so did many *others* (167; emphasis added).

Not only does Chand point out the government's inaction, he also satirizes Nehru's independence speech. By playing with pronouns – replacing the first person singular with the second person plural, as shown in italics – he questions the idea of national experience. For some, having a tryst with destiny means taking part in fancy ceremonies; for others, it implies dying in the most terrible circumstances. This ironic discrepancy creates a tone of bitterness.

Chand then recalls the fate of three of his acquaintances: his colleague Prem Singh, assassinated in Lahore where he had returned to recover his wife's jewellery; the daughter of his servant, Sundari, raped after seeing her husband being castrated on the way back from

their wedding; Sunder Singh, finally, an army officer who shot his family to spare them from dehydration while blocked in a train:

No one was allowed to get off. Sunder Singh's children cried for water and food. So did everyone else. Sunder Singh gave them his urine to drink. Then that dried up too so he pulled out his revolver and shot them all. . . . Then he lost his nerve. He put his revolver on his temple but did not fire. There was no point in killing himself. The train had begun to move. . . . He did not redeem *the pledge*. Only his family did (169; emphasis added).

For victims, therefore, Nehru's pledge of *Purna Swaraj* (or complete independence) becomes a veritable pledge of death.

This passage is subversive in the double sense of "sub-version" and "subversion." It is by substituting national history with a series of individual stories that Chand inverts the meaning of Nehru's speech. By effecting a change in the scale and the subject of history, the glorious *hypotext* of independence is transformed into an outraged *hypertext* of Partition that refuses to countenance the silencing of victims⁷.

Khushwant Singh himself seems to have strongly believed in the importance, or even the duty to remember the events of 1947. "We must not forget the Partition because it is relevant today. We must remember that it did in fact happen and can happen again", he declared at the premiere of the film adaptation of his novel in 1998 (Dhawan 14).

Nevertheless, is it not possible to detect more subtle and insidious forms of forgetting in *Train to Pakistan*?

A number of narratives – both historiographical and testimonial – keep the violence of 1947 at a certain distance. To quote a historian: "violence is . . . not only condemned but is so often attributed – often as a means to disguise the collective guilt of a community – to anti-

social elements, unscrupulous politicians, and religious fanatics” (Hasan 42)⁸. In this type of representation, barbaric acts are silenced when they are mentioned and forgotten just as they are remembered; attributing responsibility to someone else is a way to exonerate oneself while also reducing violence to a marginal phenomenon.

Does Khushwant Singh’s novel question this second and fairly dominant discourse on the Partition? The villagers of Mano Majra are the subjects of the narrative in a narratological sense; simply put, they are the *actants* whose quest it is to resist an expansion of communalism coming from the outside⁹.

In the initial situation, Mano Majra is described as a pastoral utopia, an oasis of peace in a desert of violence¹⁰. The humble village is organised symbolically around a sacred banyan tree, itself surrounded by the Sikh temple, the mosque and the residence of the only Hindu villager. The depiction of local customs and beliefs in the iterative present creates an impression of permanence and the inhabitants seem to live outside of history until Partition: “it had always been so, until the summer of 1947” (7).

Then comes a series of four trials for the villagers. Firstly, violence erupts when the only Hindu inhabitant is assassinated by criminals coming from a nearby village – Malli and his gang – and a train of corpses stops at the village. Tension mounts but the members of both Hindu and Sikh communities gather under the banyan tree until the arrival of the police.

Secondly, Hukum Chand tries to sow discord in Mano Majra to encourage the Muslims to leave for Pakistan and thus maintain law and order. He has Malli released and spreads a rumour according to which the murder was committed by Muslim League activists. The naive villagers fall into the trap: “the head constable’s visit had divided Mano Majra into two halves as neatly as a knife cuts through a pat of butter” (115). The Sikhs meet in the temple and some want to draw blood. When the Muslims join them, however, friendship overcomes animosity and a scene of reconciliation ensues.

Thirdly, to ensure everyone's safety, the inhabitants decide together to have the Muslims evacuated to a refugee camp nearby until calm returns. Little do they know that the soldiers in charge of the transfer will deport the Muslims to Pakistan and force them to leave most of their belongings behind. When the Sikh villagers refuse to seize those goods, Malli and another group of outsiders accept. The complicity between intruders and the solidarity among villagers is explicit:

It is all settled, said the Sikh officer, speaking softly in Punjabi. I have arranged that these people *from the next village* will look after the cattle, carts, and houses, till it is over. I will have a list made and sent over to you. His colleague did not reply. He had a sardonic smile on his face. *Mano Majra Sikhs and Muslims looked on helplessly.* (130; emphasis added)

Finally, after the arrival of a second train of corpses, a band of Sikh soldiers led by a reckless youth taunt the villagers and manipulate them into attacking the train that will leave for Pakistan with Mano Majra Muslims on board. Once again, it is Malli and some unknown refugees who volunteer first:

‘Are there any volunteers?’

‘My life is at your disposal,’ said *Malli*, heroically. . . .

‘Bravo,’ said the speaker. . . . ‘Who else is willing to lay down his life?’

Four of Malli's companions stepped over the threshold. They were followed by many others, *mostly refugees*. *Some villagers* who had only recently wept at the departure of their Muslim friends also stood up to volunteer. (144; emphasis added)

The narrative comes to a resolution when Juggut Singh – an anti-hero known in the village for his petty crimes – sacrifices himself to sabotage the attack. He falls to his death after cutting the rope set up above the railway line to kill those sitting on the roof and to force the train to a stop, thereby saving his lover Nooran and the rest of the Mano Majra Muslims.

In *Train to Pakistan*, therefore, violence is carried out by the opponents of the narrative: outsiders, criminals and secondary characters who do not elicit empathy from the reader. The villagers are not responsible because they are manipulated, nor are they guilty since the only crime they could have committed is prevented and atoned for by a sacrifice. Their only fault, it seems, is their innocence.

Does Khushwant Singh's novel offer a counter-representation of the Partition? The answer depends on our perception of dominant discourses. Undoubtedly, it is a subversive text that draws the reader's attention to an oft-forgotten chapter of history. However, as in numerous other accounts, it also keeps violence at bay by attributing responsibility not to the subjects but to the opponents of the narrative – to “other”, criminal and marginal characters.

Among the two types of forgetting that have been dealt with (silence and self-exoneration), one was mentioned in *Train to Pakistan* but the other was inspired by the reading of historiography. Perhaps this can explain why the first has attracted the attention of literary critics while the second has not. It might therefore be time to use the latest works of historians to revisit other Partition novels from a fresh perspective.

Notes

1. Since 1947, two monuments dedicated to the memory of Partition victims have been erected: the Bab-e-Pakistan (or Gate of Pakistan), due to be completed in 2014 in Lahore, and the Martyr's Memorial in Chandigarh (Khan 200-201).
2. According to a study published in 2001, "the two narratives come remarkably close in the cursory manner in which they deal with the violence associated with Partition. The horror and suffering that millions of ordinary men and women faced receive no more than a few lines of cold recording in most Indian and Pakistani textbooks" (Kumar 107).
3. In the words of historian Gyanendra Pandey, "if it is the question of guilt and the necessity of the remembrance of suffering that has animated the German debate on the historiography of the Holocaust, it is – as I have stressed – the question of India's unity, and the need to forget in the interests of that unity, that Indians are asked to take (and to a large extent have taken) as guide in their historical scholarship on the Partition of 1947" (60). To be precise, historians have long written about the relations between the Congress and the Muslim League until the Radcliffe Line was drawn in 1947. However, it has only been a dozen years since some have started to conduct interviews with survivors (see Butalia; Pandey; Menon and Bhasin).
4. To quote Pandey one more time, "there is a wide chasm between the historians' apprehension of 1947 and what we might call a more popular, survivors' account of it – between history and memory, as it were. Nationalism and nationalist historiography, I shall argue, have made an all too facile separation between 'Partition' and 'violence.' This is one that survivors seldom make: for in their view, Partition was violence, a cataclysm, a world (or worlds) torn apart" (6).

5. During press conferences, Amitav Ghosh called the novel “a classic”, while Salman Rushdie said it was “the only good book on the theme [of Partition]” (Roy 33-4).
6. For one critic, “all the venom and indignation felt by [Khushwant Singh] at the ghastly human tragedy was poured by him with scathing irony and stark realism in this memorable work of fiction” (Raizada 127).
7. French structuralist Gérard Genette defines hypertextuality as “any relationship uniting a text B (hypertext) to an earlier text A (hypotext), upon which it is grafted in a manner that is not that of commentary” (“toute relation unissant un texte B (hypertexte) à un texte antérieur A (hypotexte) sur lequel il se greffe d'une manière qui n'est pas celle du commentaire”; Genette 12). In this particular case, Hukum Chand's hypertext about Prem Singh, Sundari and Sunder Singh is derived from Nehru's hypotext about India.
8. While Hasan's statement is about a collection of history books, Pandey reached the same conclusion after conducting interviews in the Punjab: “The standard story I heard in Gharuan was that of the exceptional peace and harmony of this large Sikh village. ‘Nothing happened in the village;’ ‘our Muslims were unharmed;’ ‘not a single woman or child was touched [abducted or raped] here.’ Whatever violence occurred, occurred outside the village, I was repeatedly told” (181; addition in orig.).
9. An *actant*, as opposed to a character, is not defined by its psychological character but by the function it serves in a narrative. The function of a subject is – with the aid of *helpers* and against the hindrance of *opponents* – to seek an object, in this case inter-communal peace and harmony (Greimas 172-6).
10. The novel tends to follow the archetypal narrative sequence described by a number of narratologists: initial situation, node, action, denouement and final situation (see for example Adam 58).

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